Requesting a website to be unblocked

Article KB0010029 | Owner: Network Support | Subcategory: Website / DNS / proxy | Applies to: Windows 11 laptops (Dell Latitude 5440/7440, Lenovo ThinkPad T14/X1 Carbon, HP EliteBook 840), macOS 14/15 MacBook Pro/Air, Mobile devices using ACME-Corp Wi-Fi or VPN, Any device connected to Acme Global wired or wireless networks

Summary

Users may encounter errors when trying to reach internal or external websites while connected to the Acme Global network. This article describes common symptoms, underlying causes, and step-by-step guidance for both end-users and service-desk agents to diagnose and resolve website-access issues, including how to request an unblock when a site is filtered.

Symptoms

- Website fails to load and shows a blank page or timeout
- Browser displays error messages such as DNS_PROBE_FINISHED_NXDOMAIN, ERR_CONNECTION_RESET, or PROXY_ERROR
- Internal site returns "Access denied - site blocked by web filter" or similar warning
- Ping to the site succeeds but HTTP/HTTPS requests fail

Common causes

- Stale DNS cache or incorrect IP address after network change
- Manual proxy settings configured in the browser or OS interfering with automatic proxy discovery
- Site categorized as blocked by the corporate web-filter (category-based URL filtering)
- VPN split-tunnel missing route for the destination network
- Captive-portal or 802.1X authentication required on Wi-Fi before traffic is allowed

Overview

When a user reports that a website will not load, the problem can stem from DNS resolution, IP configuration, proxy settings, or the corporate web-filter. Understanding the most common failure points helps both users and the service desk quickly restore access or determine when a formal unblock request is needed.

Preliminary Checks

Before diving into troubleshooting, perform a few quick checks to isolate the issue. Verify whether other websites load correctly, confirm that the device is connected to the ACME-Corp Wi-Fi or GlobalProtect VPN, and note any specific error message displayed in the browser. If the problem affects only a single site, the cause is more likely to be DNS, proxy, or filtering rather than a broad network outage.

Self-Help Procedure

Follow these steps to clear common local causes of website-access problems. After each step, try to reach the site again in a fresh browser window.

1. Close all browser windows and reopen the browser.
2. Flush the DNS cache: on Windows open Command Prompt and run ipconfig /flushdns; on macOS open Terminal and run sudo dscacheutil -flushcache; sudo killall -HUP mDNSResponder.
3. Renew the IP address: on Windows run ipconfig /renew; on macOS run sudo ipconfig set en0 DHCP (replace en0 with the active interface if needed).
4. Disable any manual proxy configuration: Windows Settings -> Network & Internet -> Proxy -> turn off "Use a proxy server"; macOS System Preferences -> Network -> Advanced -> Proxies -> uncheck all protocols.
5. Disconnect and reconnect to the ACME-Corp Wi-Fi or GlobalProtect VPN to ensure a clean network session.
6. Attempt to access the website again. If it still fails, record the exact error message and proceed to request an unblock.

Service Desk Procedure

Agents should use this procedure to validate the user's environment, check for filtering, and initiate an unblock request when appropriate.

1. Ask the user to ping the target host and run a traceroute; confirm they are reachable via the corporate network or VPN.
2. From the user's machine, run nslookup <site> and compare the returned address with the expected internal or public IP; note any mismatches.
3. Check for manual proxy settings using netsh winhttp show proxy (Windows) or scutil --proxy (macOS); ensure no unwanted proxy is configured.
4. Log into the web-filter/firewall console and search for the user's IP address and the requested URL to see if the traffic is blocked by category.
5. If the site is blocked, create a ticket in the Network Support queue, attach a screenshot of the block page, include the full URL, business justification, and requested duration of access.
6. Inform the user of the ticket number and advise them to retry the site after receiving confirmation that the request has been approved.

Verification

After the issue is believed to be resolved, confirm that normal browsing has been restored before closing the ticket.

1. Have the user reload the site in a fresh browser window and verify that the page loads without error.
2. If the site is an internal application, perform a quick functional test (e.g., login, data retrieval) to ensure it works as expected.
3. Ask the user to browse to a different external site to confirm general Internet access is still functional.
4. Document the outcome and close the ticket with the resolution "Website unblocked / access restored".

When to escalate

If the website remains inaccessible after completing the self-help and service-desk procedures, or if the web-filter indicates the site is categorized as a security threat (malware, phishing, or illegal content), escalate the ticket to the Security Operations team. Include the user's IP address, timestamp, full URL, screenshot of any block page, and relevant firewall or proxy logs for analysis.

Keywords: website unblock, blocked site, DNS_PROBE_FINISHED, proxy error, web filter, access denied, flush DNS, renew IP, manual proxy, GlobalProtect, ACME-Corp Wi-Fi, Network Support, Security Operations